

Project Overview

Project: Personal TTRPG System

Role: System Designer / GM

Duration: 2022 – present

Format: Custom tabletop RPG system

Summary: A custom tabletop RPG system focused on character build flexibility and system-aided storytelling. I designed and iterated the core mechanics through long-term campaign play.

The Ability Drain System

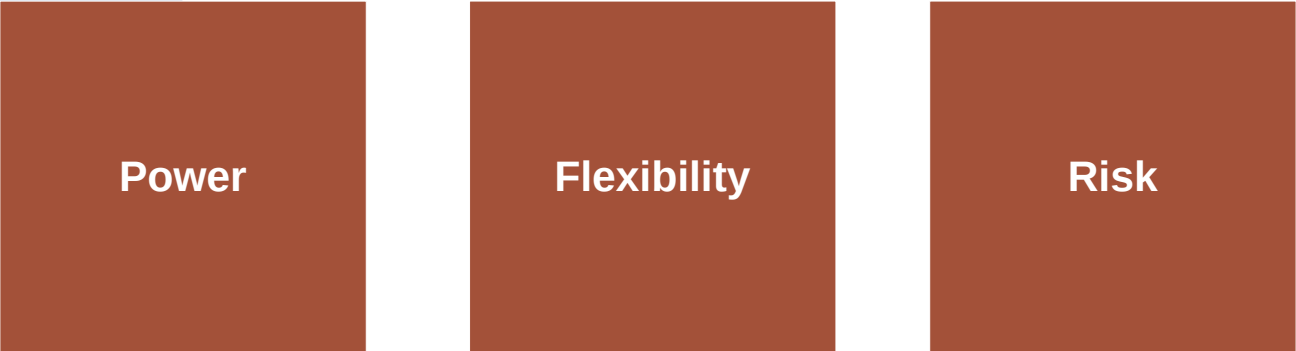
Design Goal

I wanted characters to feel powerful and competent with their abilities – how you imagine them in a book or movie.

Their effects needed to feel powerful and useful while remaining flexible in their application, making them memorable without removing the risks of overuse.

Players should make meaningful decisions in tense situations, where their powers are stretched to their limits and they (as a player and character) are tempted by even greater strength, but also greater danger.

The system draws inspiration from spell design in Pathfinder and Dungeons & Dragons, while its casting mechanics are closer to Shadowrun 5e.



Power

Flexibility

Risk

System Design

Each class-specific active ability has a level that determines whether a character can use it and how much **Drain** it generates.

Each time you use it you roll a number of dice (from 1d4 to 4d10) based on its level. The character gets **Drain** equal to the roll minus their **Class Attribute Modifier**. Higher-level abilities therefore generate more Drain, while character progression increasingly mitigates the cost.

Characters can accumulate Drain **up to a threshold without immediate consequences**. Once that threshold is reached, each further increase requires a **Drain Resistance Test against the character's total Drain**.

On a **success**, there is no immediate consequence, but continued Drain accumulation makes subsequent tests increasingly difficult.

On a **failure**, you suffer a random consequence by rolling 2d6 and looking at the smaller number.

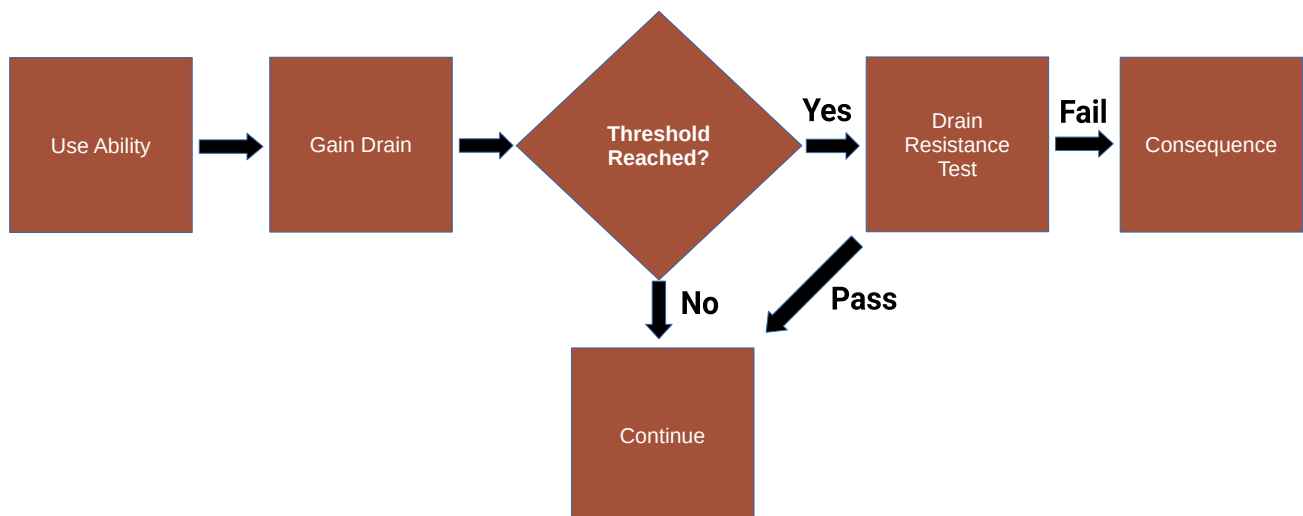
Key outcomes:

Double 6s: Only reduce your **Drain**. You got lucky.

Smallest = 2 to 5: Small negative condition, but reduce your **Drain**. Not so bad.

Single 1, the player gets a tempting choice: The character gets to reduce their Drain (which refuels their powers) but some external force represented by the GM gets some power over them (called points of influence) or they resist, stay fully in control but suffer Overload, which is a major debuff to their powers for a while.

Double 1, they get the same offer, but get in addition either a mighty power surge buff that gets stronger every time they take it or a stronger overload if they resist.



Balance Overview

Low-level reliability: single-die rolls plus attribute mitigation make commonly used abilities predictable.

Natural progression: increasing attributes gradually make old abilities inexpensive, keeping them relevant later in the game.

High-level cost: powerful abilities intentionally remain capable of triggering Drain resistance from a single use.

Balancing & Design Reasoning

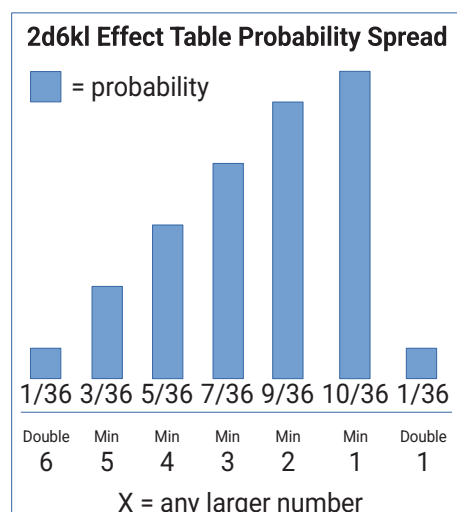
Low-level abilities use a single Drain die and are reduced by the Class Attribute Modifier, producing predictable costs and allowing frequent use. As **characters improve**, early abilities can become effectively free, keeping them relevant as reliable baseline actions while stronger abilities remain the main source of Drain.

Higher-level abilities deliberately increase both expected Drain and variance. The most powerful abilities sit outside the normal range of regular play and may trigger a Drain Resistance test from a single use, making them exceptional tools rather than routine actions.

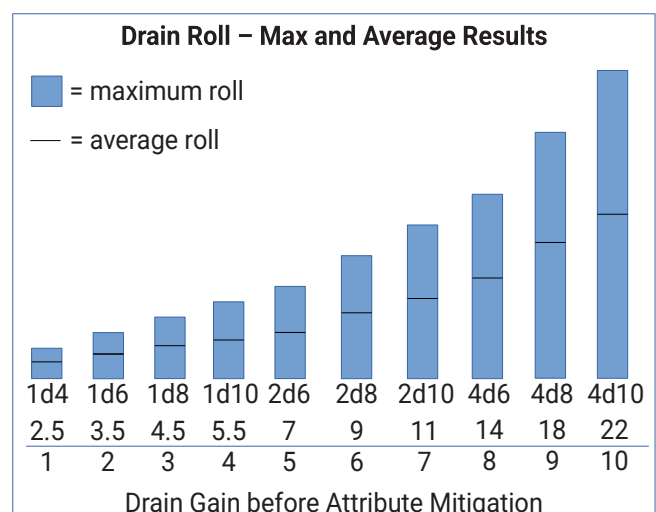
The Drain Effects Table uses 2d6 keep lowest to concentrate results around common consequences while making extreme outcomes rare. Results are grouped into roughly three categories: Overload, Temptation, and other effects. Any result containing a 1 triggers Temptation, creating an easy-to-remember rule and linking a distinctive die result to one of the system's most significant choices.

Temptation creates a trade between mechanical and narrative power. The GM may offer escalating benefits in exchange for influence, but the final decision always remains with the player, preserving player agency.

The distribution concentrates results around ordinary consequences while making the extreme outcomes deliberately rare.



The progression deliberately increases both expected Drain and variance, allowing low-level abilities to remain dependable while high-level abilities become increasingly risky.



Playtesting & Iteration

Iteration 1 – Drain Accumulation

Original: Frequent use combined with a few unlucky high rolls could take a character out of commission too early.

Problem: This forced affected players to rely on 0-level abilities, slowing their progression and reducing their ability to participate while other characters remained fully effective.

Change: Drain gained was reduced by the character's Class Attribute Modifier.

Result: Low-level abilities became more consistently available and isolated bad rolls had less impact. Subsequent playtests showed improved pacing.

Iteration 2 – Drain Recovery

Original: Drain could be recovered by 1d6 (increasing at higher levels) by taking a rest in the game or removing it completely by ending the day.

Problem: Playtests showed that characters relied more heavily on Drain-generating abilities than expected, making the recovery mechanics too slow for the intended pace.

Change: Short Rests were changed to halve the current Drain.

Result: Faster, more enjoyable pace and positive feedback.

The same recovery mechanic was also applied to items and other effects, with similarly positive results.

Iteration 3 – Temptation

Original: Resistance Tests had generic consequences such as damage.

Problem: Uninteresting effects and low impact. Tests felt more like an annoyance than anything else.

Change: Temptation and Overload were introduced.

Result: Players showed a strong emotional response when Temptation put character control at risk, creating the tension the mechanic was designed to produce.

Design Outcome

Iteration shifted the system away from primarily restricting ability use and toward creating meaningful risk when players deliberately push their characters. Low-level abilities remain dependable, while stronger abilities introduce escalating mechanical and narrative consequences. Further balancing continues through campaign playtesting.